does not fully recognize the fluctuations in the Tatmadaw's support toward the government peace agenda throughout the peace process.

This chapter acknowledges the importance of the aforementioned explanations in assessing the prospects of the ongoing peace process. However, they are insufficient by themselves to answer the question of how the government managed to keep both the Tatmadaw and the EAGs adhering to the peace process despite political and security constraints.

This chapter is descriptive rather than explanatory in most of its content. Throughout, the focus is on institutional determinants: the roles of the civilian technical team, the Myanmar Peace Center (MPC), and its coping strategy with respect to the peace process. I will denote the MPC as the centre of a peace "political community" — the core group of interrelated policy actors pursuing a matter of public policy important to them for instrumental reasons (Miller and Demir 2007, p. 137). The specific research puzzles I intend to address are: (i) is there a policy community centred on the MPC substantial enough to have been responsible for the sustained peace process; and (ii) if so, how did it manage to shape the dynamic of the peace negotiations in Myanmar in recent years such that it produced this sustained peace process?

In my explanation, I will argue that the role of the MPC as the centre of peace policy community and its approaches particularly shaped the dynamic of the peace process in Myanmar. Despite political and security constraints, the centre of the policy community, the MPC, was vital in sustaining the peace process throughout the Thein Sein administration. It has been employing a piecemeal approach in its dealings with the Tatmadaw and the EAGs through formal and informal binding mechanisms. This approach has helped the major stakeholders stick to their respective commitments during the ongoing process.

There are four sections in this chapter. Firstly, the research design is explained. Secondly, the empirical foundations of the state's approaches to President Thein Sein's peace project are discussed. Thirdly, my central argument is presented in two parts: I analyse the institutional trajectory of the centre of the peace policy community — the MPC — and examine its piecemeal approach to the ethnic peace process. My explanation uses two case studies to analyse formal and informal binding of the piecemeal approach. Finally, the conclusions are presented.